

# App store mechanics

Week 8 Lecture 1 · B2C to \$10k MRR

Autumn 2026

## What we'll cover

- The submission economy: what review actually costs you in time and risk
- Apple vs Google review: where they agree, where they diverge
- TestFlight and Play internal-testing: the one-person release pipeline
- IAP, subscriptions, and pricing tiers: what the stores permit
- Release notes as marketing copy
- When NOT to be on the app stores at all

# The submission economy

## Review is a tax on iteration speed

- Apple review: median 24 hrs, 99th percentile 3-5 days (Apple, 2026)
- Google Play new app review: 3-7 days for personal accounts
- Every rejection adds a full cycle: fix, resubmit, wait again
- Week 8 milestone depends on a live build — plan for one rejection

## Apple: the five sections that matter

- **Safety (§1):** objectionable content, kids category, data security
- **Performance (§2):** completeness, accurate metadata, TestFlight policy
- **Business (§3):** IAP rules, prohibited monetization, subscription terms
- **Design (§4):** minimum functionality, copycat rule
- **Legal (§5):** privacy, IP, gambling
- Source: Apple App Store Review Guidelines (2026), all five sections

## The rejections that hit solo founders hardest

- Missing privacy policy URL when app requests any permission (§5.1.1)
- Incomplete content: app crashes or shows placeholder data (§2.1)
- IAP for content available outside the app for less money (§3.1.1)
- Sign in with Apple missing when other social logins are offered (§4.8)
- Metadata that does not match the actual app behavior (§2.3.1)

## Google Play: three tracks, one submission

| Track          | Testers     | Review time        | Discoverable? |
|----------------|-------------|--------------------|---------------|
| Internal       | up to 100   | Minutes, no review | No            |
| Closed (alpha) | up to 2,000 | ~24 hrs            | No            |
| Open (beta)    | Unlimited   | ~24 hrs            | Yes           |

- Personal accounts created after Nov 2023: 12 closed testers for 14 days before production access
- Source: Google Play testing tracks docs (2026)

# The release pipeline for one person



## TestFlight: what it actually does

- Distributes pre-release builds to up to 10,000 external testers
- Internal testers (your team): available within 30 minutes of upload
- External testers: brief TestFlight review required (24-48 hrs)
- Apple Review Guidelines §2.9: beta apps must be functionally complete
- TestFlight is NOT a way to avoid review indefinitely

## Play internal testing: fastest path to a real device

- Build available to 100 testers within minutes, no review required
- Only requires: signed .aab, valid Play Console account, valid manifest
- Use internal track for week 8 milestone; upgrade to closed/open later
- Source: Google Play testing tracks docs (2026)

## IAP vs subscriptions: what the stores take

- App Store: 30% commission, drops to 15% after year 1 (Small Business Program)
- Google Play: 15% on first \$1M/year for subscriptions (reduced rate program)
- Both stores require IAP for in-app digital purchases — no Stripe checkout bypassing the store
- Family sharing: subscriptions can be shared; individual IAP purchases cannot
- PWA subscriptions: charge via your own payment processor, no 30% cut

## Release notes as marketing copy

- Release notes appear in search results and on the store listing
- Most founders write: "Bug fixes and performance improvements" — this is wasted space
- Better pattern: name one user-visible change, describe the benefit, one line max
- Example: "Paywall now shows trial length before you tap — no surprises"
- Release notes are indexed by the stores and affect keyword ranking (RevenueCat ASO guide, 2022)

When NOT to be on the app stores

## PWA-first is a legitimate distribution decision

- No review delay, no 30% commission, no IAP mandate
- langobee (language-learning PWA) ships entirely as a web app: home-screen install, offline support, push notifications
- The trade-off: no organic store search, no featuring, no App Store badge trust signal
- Right choice when: web-first audience, subscription via your own processor, or you want to iterate faster than review allows

## The honest decision matrix

| Factor             | Stores win                 | PWA wins                           |
|--------------------|----------------------------|------------------------------------|
| Discovery          | Organic search + featuring | SEO + paid                         |
| Commission         | 15-30% of revenue          | 0%                                 |
| Iteration speed    | Review cycle (days)        | Instant deploy                     |
| Trust signal       | App Store badge            | Domain + design                    |
| Push notifications | Native, reliable           | Web push (Android better than iOS) |

## Take-aways

1. Review is a tax on iteration: treat it as a constraint, not a surprise.
2. The five Apple review sections map to distinct rejection categories — read §2 and §3 before submitting.
3. Google Play internal-testing is the fastest path to a real device (minutes, no review).
4. Release notes are indexed copy: treat them like a micro-changelog + micro-ad.
5. PWA-first is not a compromise — for web-first products it is the correct distribution decision.



"The app name carries the strongest ranking weight in both stores."

Thomas Kribernegg, RevenueCat ASO guide (2022)

## What's next

- **Section (this week):** Ship your build via one of three paths. Non-negotiable milestone.
- **Lecture 2:** ASO + screenshots — title, subtitle, keywords, the first-three rule, and ASA basics.
- **Reading:** Week 8 reading covers all three distribution paths and the Friday capstone scaffold.
- **HW 4 (Retention engine):** Due this week — separate from the store submission milestone.